

Your Essay Analysis

Your Essay Graded

● Purpose (P) ● Coherence (C) ● Language (L) ● Mechanics (M)

Marking Scheme Explained

P - Purpose: Purpose: relevance to question, clear aim, original points, personal response (if required).

C - Coherence: Coherence: logical flow, focused argument, integrated quotes, introduction/conclusion.

L - Language: Language: formal register, clear expression, varied phrasing, interesting vocabulary.

M - Mechanics: Mechanics: grammar, punctuation, capitalisation, syntax, British English adherence.

Question

"There is often a profound sadness to be found at the heart of Patrick Kavanagh's eloquent poems." Do you agree with this assessment of his poetry? Develop your response with reference to the poetry by Patrick Kavanagh on your Leaving Certificate course.

Your Answer Analysis

Patrick Kavanagh's detailed focus on the mundane, whether it be parochial or natural, functions as a microcosm of his outlook on the world. As a countryside poet from Inniskeen, his poetry elucidates the subtle but profound sadness veneered under the eloquent descriptions of nature he portrays. He feels alienated, yet at the same time, it would be fallacious to dismiss his poetry as sad. He feels alienated, yet at the same time, it would be fallacious to dismiss his poetry as sad. In the poems "Inniskeen Road: July Evening", "Shancoduff", "Canal Bank Walk" and "Lines Written on a Seat on the Grand Canal, Dublin" there is often, albeit not always, a tremendous and palpable sadness.

This is a strong introduction, but you can state your position more clearly in response to the question.

Good work mentioning the poems you will discuss.

"elucidates the subtle but profound sadness veneered under the eloquent descriptions" is a very sophisticated use of language.

Check for any repeated sentences.

Good intro, but state your position more clearly.

Firstly, the poem "Inniskeen Road: July Evening" seems inconspicuous. Kavanagh details the "dance in Billy Brennan's barn" and "the half-talk code of mysteries / And the wink-and-elbow language of delight", embellishing the first octet with euphonious alliteration, while the enjambment mirrors the hustle and bustle of the party. Beneath this eloquence, though, lies a deep-seated feeling of alienation amid the quietness of the "secrecies of stone". The sestet alludes to "Alexander Selkirk [who] knew the plight" of this sadness, given his history as a voluntary castaway on an island in the Pacific Ocean. Therefore, we can feel a profound sadness at the heart of the poem. Even though the townsfolk of Kavanagh's time romanticised a poet's solitude through the "solemn talk of contemplation", it is something to be despised to Kavanagh, something that isolates him from society rather than plunge him deeper into his poetry.

Excellent analysis of "Inniskeen Road: July Evening".

Use topic sentences to link back to the question, especially at the beginning and end of paragraphs.



"euphonious alliteration", "deep-seated feeling of alienation" are very good expressions.

Use topic sentences to link back to the question.

"Likewise, "Shancoduff" also hides sentiments of isolation under the pleasing depictions of nature, though differently. Whereas "Inniskeen Road: July Evening" portrays alienation, "Shancoduff" focuses on ostracisation. Immediately, Kavanagh writes that "[his] black hills have never seen the sun rising", and that they face away from the sun, "look[ing] north towards Armagh". Through the imagery of the "black hills", Kavanagh details the infertility of the land while conveying a sense of perpetual darkness, setting a sad tone. Yet he also feels a spiritual, hyperbolic connection to Shancoduff, calling it "[his] Alps", but this infertility leads to the "cattle-drovers" condemning his decision to spend money on it. To them, land is prized solely on monetary value. The climax of this sadness shines through when Kavanagh retaliates against these remarks, "I hear and is my heart not badly shaken?" He delivers this line with an undertone of sadness, but given the rhyme with "forsaken" — the only rhyme in the poem — he insinuates that this sadness is at the heart of the poem through an established cadence, rather than the prosaic imagery of Shancoduff itself.

Great analysis of "Shancoduff".

Good use of linking phrases, e.g. "Likewise".

"The climax of this sadness shines through" is a very good use of language.

Good analysis, but explain how this relates to the eloquence of his poems.

However, his canal poems are much more multifaceted in their tone. "Canal Bank Walk" presents Kavanagh's haven amid Dublin's flurry of activity, and the healing power of "the habitual, the banal". He personifies the canal playfully, interweaving it with neologisms: "Leafy-with-love banks and the green waters of the canal / Pouring redemption for me". Redemption from what, exactly? He may be alluding to the sexual stigmas surrounding Catholic doctrine, comparing "the couple kissing on an old seat" with the image of "a bird gathering materials for the Word", depicting it as a sight to be cherished rather than an act to be damned, as most relationships were still transactional in Kavanagh's time. Through evoking a pun on the next line, claiming the act is "abandoned to its delirious beat", he strengthens this interpretation. On the one hand, it could simply mean ecstatic, but it could also mean utterly unorthodox as per religious norms. This imagery is ultimately nuanced; even though I agree with this contextualisation — which would therefore carry a profound sadness underneath the eloquent poetry — this is not the central theme of the poem, and Kavanagh leaves the poem open to interpretation by the reader. Given this complexity, I disagree with the statement, which merely categorises his poetry as sad.

Insightful analysis of "Canal Bank Walk".

Use more linking phrases to connect this paragraph to the previous one.

"This imagery is ultimately nuanced" is a very good use of language.

Insightful analysis, but focus more on the sadness aspect.

The final canal poem — "Lines Written on a Seat on the Grand Canal, Dublin" — operates on a similar principle, where more poignant interpretations lie beneath the facade of natural imagery. He invokes a sense of child-like wonder through the use of neologisms once again, such as the "stilly" and "greeny" canal water "where by a lock Niagarously roars". Moreover, Kavanagh conveys the beauty of

his desired place of commemoration through allusion, insisting that "[n]o one will speak in prose / Who finds his way to these Parnassian islands" — a reference to Mount Parnassus, the home of poetry in Greek mythology and potentially a reference to his love for childhood stories. In this way, there is a nostalgic sadness to be felt throughout the poem given his meditative use of tone. Just like in "Canal Bank Walk", however, the sadness is subtle and ambiguous, but one cannot doubt that he has considered the last of his days nonetheless. Therefore, there is a melancholy nature to the poem, but his commemoration still remains at the heart of the poem.

Excellent analysis of "Lines Written on a Seat on the Grand Canal, Dublin".

Good use of transitional phrases, e.g. "Just like in".

"nostalgic sadness", "meditative use of tone" are very good expressions.

Excellent analysis, but consider exploring alternative interpretations.

In conclusion, Kavanagh's eloquent and legendary imagery seems to hide deeper sentiments of alienation, ostracisation and nostalgia — all related to sadness and a need for belonging while having lived as a countryside poet. Nevertheless, he leaves room for ascertainment; his parochial poetry should not be dismissed as depressing. Throughout "Inniskeen Road: July Evening", "Shancoduff", "Canal Bank Walk" and "Lines Written on a Seat on the Grand Canal, Dublin", Kavanagh progressively elucidates the thesis. In the words of the critic Horace Reynolds, Patrick Kavanagh's poetry "has both beauty and sharpness in it". There is often, but not always, a tremendous sadness to be felt at the core of his poetry.

This is a strong conclusion, but you can summarise your main points more explicitly.

Good work mentioning the poems and the critic in your conclusion.

"he progressively elucidates the thesis" is a very good use of language.

H1

Grade Calculation

Total Score Calculation

Purpose: 14/15

Coherence: 14/15

Language: 14/15

Mechanics: 5/5

Final Mark: 47/50 (94%)

Estimated Grade: This is an estimated grade. Pulc is often a harsh marker and sometimes makes mistakes. Always rely on your teacher's grade and feedback first. For some FAQs about estimated grades, see .

